



◀ Geisha notes

This late 19th-century photograph shows geishas playing traditional Japanese music. Known as *jikata*, they learn from a very young age to play instruments such as the *shamisen*, a long-necked guitar.

THROUGH THE AGES

Music

Since medieval times, women have played an important role in music as both composers and performers across many genres. Today, although there are more women musicians than ever before, the majority of the music industry's decision makers are still men.

WOMEN'S ROLES in music were initially very limited. Medieval European women were restricted to liturgical chants, sung in convents during worship. Most famed in this scene was 11th-century Benedictine abbess Hildegard von Bingen, one of the first known composers, although she has only recently been credited as such by historians. From a remote monastery in the Rhineland, she composed around 69 pieces, many of which are still performed today.

In contrast, Renaissance noblewomen were expected to have a musical background, and in the late 16th century the *concerto delle donne* was formed in the court of Ferrara, Italy. This small ensemble of female singers was so famed for its virtuosity that others soon emerged. These successes paved the way for women to compete for operatic fame with male *castrati*—well-trained boys who continued to have higher voices as adults.

There was fresh opportunity for women during the Baroque period, beginning in the 17th century, especially in the new genre of opera. Francesca Caccini, from Florence, was likely the first female opera composer, her only extant example being *The Liberation of Ruggiero from the Island of Alcina* (1625). Instrumental Baroque composers included Italian nun Isabella Leonarda and French harpsichordist Elisabeth Jacquet de la Guerre.

Modern musicians

After the dissolution of European courts in the late 18th century, the growing middle classes helped push women forward by giving young girls music training. By the 19th century, women began to gain recognition for

their skills, with players such as Clara Schumann coming to prominence. In England, Dame Ethel Smyth's composition "March of the Women" which became the anthem of the British women's suffrage movement.

In the 20th century, orchestras became mixed gender ensembles and more doors opened for female conductors and

